SHEIKH'S ARK Gulammohammed Sheikh *'s acrylic on canvas, 'Kaarawaan'*



plex philosophical constructs. And then there are the four ingenious *kaawads*, going beyond their prosaic role as travelling shrines, their multiple doors opening into galaxies peopled by the likes of Kabir and Gandhi, and commentary on contemporary subjects such as the mindless construction in our cities.

Sheikh lives and works in Vadodara, the city where he studied Fine Arts (and later taught) at the Maharaja Sayajirao University, before attending the Royal College of Art in London in the 1960s. Both painting and poems as an expression of his creativity and strong opinions have stayed with him since his early years as a schoolboy. Questioning the status quo—be it in art or current affairs—has given his mind and work a certain edge that sets him apart from others of his ilk and keeps him relevant. He believes that it was his engagement with the history of Indian and world art that taught him that travelling, meeting and layering of cultures was integral to the historical flow of our collective human story. Through this exhibition, a veritable caravan of cultural wealth, which holds a telling mirror to society in subtle ways, we get a glimpse of his worldview that puts us in a reflective reverie as the best kind of art does.■

–Priya Pathiyan

PHOTOGRAPHY

WHERE THE WILD THINGS ARE

Wildlife photographer **Parag Bhatt's** stunning images pose intriguing challenges for him in the field

Parag Bhatt was bitten by the photography bug thanks to his father who had a darkroom at home where he would develop film and enlarge print, but his love for wildlife comes from his mother, who was born in Mombasa, Kenya. She would regale him with stories of how wildlife could be encountered in Kenya when travelling by road. Bhatt's first trip to Kenya was in 1994 and marked his debut as a wildlife photographer. Since then, he has travelled across the world for the perfect wildlife shot, but Kenya remains a favourite hunting ground. "It has diversity, endless plains, dramatic skies, and beautiful sunsets and sunrises, which provide great opportunities to capture wildlife in its natural habitat," he says. In 2023, his image of a tusker in Kenya titled 'The Gentle Giant of Amboseli' bagged the People's Vote Award in the 'Wildlife Non-Professional' category of the reFocus Photography Awards.

Many of Bhatt's most iconic images are on display at a group photography exhibition at The Club Mumbai, till May 11. These include photographs of a polar bear, elephants and rhinos that he shot recently. Bhatt enjoyed the unique challenges that shooting these images entailed. "For capturing the rhinos, I lay on the ground and tried to

PARAG BHATT gets his love for wildlife from his mother, who was born in Kenya

shoot when they came running towards me. It was a breathtaking sight to witness," he says. Regarding the polar bear encounter, Bhatt says, "I was in a zodiac which was bobbing due to the choppy waters. The polar bear was diving into the water and would be lost for half a minute; it would then come up in another spot. In that time, aiming long and heavy lenses and nailing the shot when it would shake off the water was very difficult."

If that isn't enough, while on a shoot, Bhatt also has to contend with lugging heavy equipment, bearing extreme weather conditions and dealing with the unpredictable behaviour of wild animals. The situation in India is even more challenging. "Though safari permits are regulated, too many vehicles converge on a sighting of a tiger. Hence, photo opportunities are at best limited, and photographers come up with similar images," he says. But, as Bhatt's mesmerising images show, the effort is worth it.■

–Amit Dixit







ANIMATED FRAMES *(Clockwise from the top) A rhino duo; a white polar bear forms a constellation with water droplets; photographer Parag Bhatt; and a matriarch leads the way across a dry lake bed*